spreading communist propaganda far and wide. A CIA analysis said:

The Soviets are trying to exploit the fluid internal situation in Bangladesh by encouraging the leftist political parties to increase agitation against the military regime of Ershad. In our view, Moscow's reasons for dabbling in Bangladesh internal politics stem from its perception that, because Ershad has not consolidated his control, the Soviets have an opportunity to check Bangladesh's drift to the West and the Islamic countries and to strengthen Leftist position. The Soviets probably recognise, however, that local pro-Sovi-ets leftists are weak, factionalised and have little chance of bringing down Er-shad's government without some major contributing issue and the support of other political groups. Instability in Bangladesh could provide an opportunity for further Soviet meddling in the subcontinent.

Vibhas told me: 'US spies were scared that the Soviet foothold in Bangladesh would provide an edge over American interests in South Asia. As an international ally, Bangladesh was a very minor interest but strategically, to counter the Soviets, it was crucial for US decision makers to keep a strong grip over the Bangladesh regime.'

Ershad may have publicly criticised New Delhi on certain foreign policy issues but by

1983, India had managed to rebuild its influence and a formidable network with the help of R&AW assets. The Indian intelligence agency's objective was very simple, 'Whoever is going to rule Dhaka must have a favourable approach towards India.'